

The Literature Review

Penulisan Proposal (CCK4CAB2)

01 What a Literature Review Is

An argument about what is known — **not** a catalogue of what you read.



Key idea: You are showing how the studies relate, where they agree or differ, and what is still missing.

Synthesis, comparison, and critical analysis lead to your research gap.

Definition

WHAT IT IS



A literature review is a structured argument about what is already known.

It selects, organises, and evaluates prior work so that a reader can see the shape of the field — and the precise point at which your study becomes necessary.



Selective

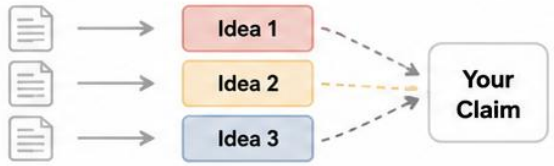
You include what bears on your questions.



- Volume is not a virtue.
- A reviewer counts relevance, not references.

Synthesised

Sources are grouped by idea, compared with one another, and made to speak to a claim that is yours.



- Organise by themes or concepts.
- Compare agreements and differences.

Evaluative

You judge what you cite: how it was done, how well, in what context, and how far it travels to yours.



- Not just summary — critical judgment.
- Show the trajectory to your study.

In short: A good literature review tells a clear story about the field and leads directly to the gap your research will address.

Four Jobs the Review Must Do

FUNCTION

Read → Analyse → Synthesize → Guide

1. Map the field

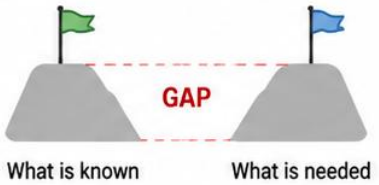
Show what has been established, by whom, and where the main lines of agreement and disagreement lie.



Goal: Give the reader a clear picture of the current knowledge landscape.

2. Demonstrate the gap

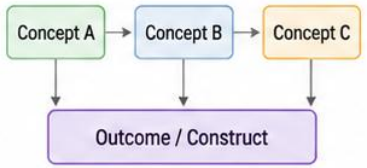
Turn the gap you claimed in the introduction into a conclusion the reader reaches from the evidence.



Goal: Make the need for your study inevitable and evidence-based.

3. Supply the framework

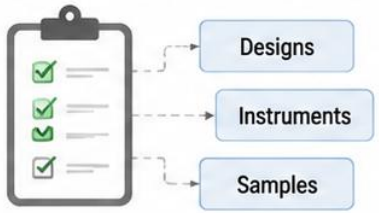
Define the concepts and relationships your study will use, drawn from theory rather than invented.



Goal: Provide the theoretical lens that connects what is known to what you will investigate.

4. Inform the method

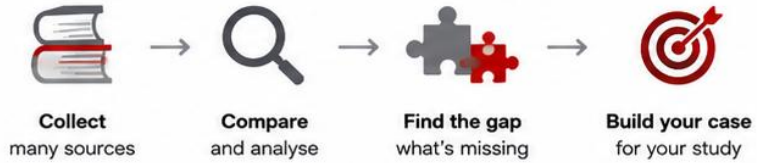
Show which designs, instruments, and samples have worked before — and justify your own choices by precedent.



Goal: Build confidence that your methods are appropriate and rigorous.

Remember: If a paragraph in your review does none of these four things, it is padding — however interesting the study it describes.

Three Things It Is Often Confused With



COMMON CONFUSION

Feature	Annotated bibliography	Chapter summary	Literature review
Organised by	One entry per source Listed separately	One paragraph per source Summarised separately	Theme, concept, or debate Grouped by ideas
Whose voice leads	Each source, in turn Source speaks for itself	Each source, in turn Source speaks for itself	Yours; sources supply the evidence You lead the argument
Sources compared?	No No comparison	Rarely Minimal comparison	Constantly — that is the work Shows patterns, agreements, and gaps
Purpose	To record what you read Information storage	To show you read it Demonstrate coverage	To argue what is known and what is missing Build the case for your study
Ends with	The last entry List ends	The last source Summary ends	A gap the reader now accepts Leads to your research questions

The most common failed review is a good annotated bibliography with the headings removed.
Without synthesis and comparison, there is no argument — only description.



Types of Review

CHOOSING AN APPROACH

Search find studies → **Screen** select relevant → **Appraise** assess quality → **Synthesize** draw conclusions

1. Narrative review

The default for a thesis proposal: selective, thematic, and argued. Transparent about scope but not exhaustive.

Select key studies → Group by themes → Build an argument

2. Systematic review

Follows a pre-registered protocol with explicit search, screening, and appraisal steps. Reproducible by design.

Search → Screen → Appraise → Synthesize

3. Scoping review

Maps the extent and nature of the evidence when a field is new or fragmented, without appraising every study.

Broad search → Chart key characteristics → Identify gaps & directions

4. Meta-analysis

Statistically pools results across comparable quantitative studies to estimate an overall effect.

Extract effect sizes → Pool statistically → Overall estimate

5. Integrative review

Combines findings from different designs — qualitative and quantitative — into one synthesis.

Qualitative studies + Quantitative studies → Integrated synthesis

6. Rapid review

A streamlined systematic method used when a decision cannot wait. Limits are stated openly.

Focused search & limits → Abbreviated screening → Timely answers

Whichever you use, say which one it is and describe how you searched.
Unstated method is the mark of an unsystematic review.

How the Section Connects to the Others

POSITION IN THE PROPOSAL

INTRODUCTION
You claim a gap and state questions.
Sets the problem and the direction.

→

LITERATURE REVIEW
You prove the gap and define the concepts.
Builds the case with evidence and definitions.

→

METHODOLOGY
You justify how the gap will be closed.
Plans the solution and shows feasibility.

Define all concepts here.	Every concept named in your questions must be defined here, from published work.	? → 📖 → 💡
Support what you claimed.	Every claim about "what is known" in your introduction must be supported here.	📣 → 📖 → ✓
Justify your method.	Every methodological choice in Week 4 should have a precedent cited here.	⚙ → 📖 → 🔬
Stay focused and aligned.	Nothing new may appear in the review that your questions never mentioned.	? → 📖 → ⊘

02 | Finding the Literature

A search you can describe, repeat, and defend.



1 Find

Use clear keywords and document your search strategy and sources.

2 Select

Screen results with explicit criteria so others can see what you kept and why.

3 Record

Save full details and search strings so the search can be reproduced exactly.

Good searches are transparent.
Be specific now, and your results will be trusted later.

From Question to Search Terms

SEARCH STRATEGY

Break your question into concepts, then list the words other authors might have used for each one.



1. Start with your research question
Define the focus of your study.

2. Break into key concepts
Identify the main ideas or variables.

3. Find synonyms and variants
Look at keywords in relevant papers.

4. Build search strings and search
Combine terms with Boolean operators.

Example search string

("feedback timing" OR "delayed feedback" OR "feedback latency") AND ("student engagement" OR "participation" OR "involvement") AND ("asynchronous course" OR "online learning" OR "distance education")

How are feedback timing and peer interaction related to student engagement in asynchronous first-year courses?

Concept	Synonyms and variants	Narrower / broader terms
Feedback timing	delayed feedback, immediate feedback, feedback latency, turnaround time	formative feedback, assessment feedback
Student engagement	behavioural engagement, participation, involvement, persistence	motivation, retention, dropout
Asynchronous course	online learning, e-learning, distance education, self-paced course	blended learning, MOOC

Tip: Take the variant terms from the papers you already have: their keyword lists tell you what vocabulary the field uses.

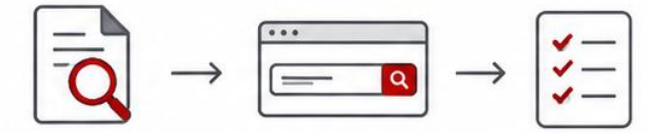


keywords | synonyms | variants | ...

Building the Search String

SEARCH SYNTAX

Use Boolean operators and symbols to build precise and reproducible searches.

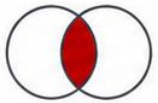


AND

Narrows: all terms must appear.

- Used to combine different concepts

`feedback AND engagement`

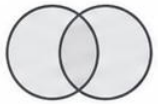


OR

Widens: any of the terms may appear.

- Use inside brackets for synonyms

`(engagement OR participation)`

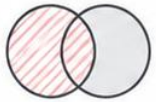


NOT

Excludes a term.

- Handle with care — it removes relevant work too

`engagement NOT marketing`



“ “

Keeps a phrase together as one unit.

- Use quotation marks for exact phrases

`“feedback timing”`



*****

Truncates the word stem to catch variants.

- Retrieves words with the same root

`engag* → engage, engaging, engagement`



Filters

Limits results by features.

- Restrict by year, language, type, or subject

`2015–2026, English, article`



Example search string

Combining operators to answer your research question.

```
(“feedback timing” OR “delayed feedback”) AND (engagement OR participation)
 AND (asynchronous OR “online learning”)
```

Where to Search



SOURCES

Use the right source for the right purpose. Different tools give you different strengths.

1. Multidisciplinary indexes

Scopus and Web of Science: curated, citation-linked, and the usual reference point for "indexed" journals.

Best for: Comprehensive, high-quality journal literature.

2. Discipline databases

ERIC for education, PubMed for health, IEEE Xplore for engineering, JSTOR for humanities.

Best for: In-depth coverage within a specific field.

3. National and open sources

Garuda, SINTA, and DOAJ for Indonesian and open-access journals that global indexes may miss.

Best for: Local context and open-access publications.

4. Google Scholar

Broad and fast, but unfiltered. Useful for finding leads; never sufficient as your only source.

Best for: Exploring topics and finding starting points.

5. Repositories and theses

Institutional repositories and dissertation archives, especially for local context and instruments.

Best for: Grey literature, datasets, theses, and instruments.

6. Citation chaining

Follow references backwards from a key paper, and citations forwards to newer work that used it.

Best for: Building a complete and up-to-date evidence trail.

Document your search.

Record where you searched, when, with which string, and how many results each returned. You will be asked.

Source → Date → Search string → Results

Deciding What Counts

INCLUSION AND EXCLUSION CRITERIA

Set these before you start screening. Deciding case by case as you go is how bias enters a review.



1. Define criteria
Agree on what to include and exclude.

2. Screen studies
Apply criteria to titles, abstracts, then full text.

3. Keep what fits
Include only studies that meet all requirements.

TYPICAL INCLUSION CRITERIA

Time window	Published within a stated window, e.g. the last ten years
Source quality	Peer-reviewed articles, or theses from recognised institutions
Population & setting	Studies of the population and setting you care about
Study type	Empirical work reporting data, not opinion pieces
Language	Written in a language you can read accurately

TYPICAL EXCLUSION CRITERIA

Insufficient text	Abstracts, posters, or conference papers without full text
Poor quality source	Publications in journals with no discernible review process
Unclear method	Studies whose method is not described well enough to judge
Different population	Work on a different population where transfer cannot be argued
Duplicate data	Duplicate reports of the same dataset

Good practice: Seminal older work is included by name, not by date rule — say so explicitly when you state your window.

The Screening Workflow

FROM RESULTS TO A READING LIST

Move step by step from thousands of results to the studies you will include.

1 Identify



- Run each search string in each database.
- Export all results with duplicates to your reference manager.

2 Screen



- Read titles and abstracts only.
- Decide against your criteria.
- Most results die here — that is normal.

3 Assess



- Read the full text of what survived.
- Check the method section before the findings.

4 Include



- Keep what is relevant and defensible.
- Record the reason each excluded study was dropped.

Track your numbers at each stage

Found → After duplicates → After title screening → After full text → Included

Reviewers ask for them, and a simple flow diagram answers the question in one glance.



Judging What You Find



SOURCE QUALITY

Use these checks to decide whether a source can be trusted and is relevant to your study.

1 Peer review status

Was the work reviewed before publication, and by whom?

- Check the journal's stated review process.
- Look for "peer-reviewed" or editorial review details.

2 Indexing and standing

Is the journal indexed in a recognised database?
Look at where the field's own leaders publish.

- Check Scopus, Web of Science, or discipline databases.
- Avoid predatory or unknown journals.

3 Methodological transparency

Can you see the sample, instrument, and analysis clearly enough to judge the finding?

- Look for enough detail to replicate or understand.
- Missing methods = weak evidence.

4 Relevance of context

Does the population, setting, and period allow the finding to travel to your study?

- Compare population, setting, time frame.
- Consider cultural and practical differences.

5 Citation trail

Who cites this work, and how?
Being cited approvingly by others in the field is a useful signal.

- Check who cites it (author, journal, intent).
- Follow references backward and forward.

6 Warning signs

Look out for signs that the source may not meet review standards.

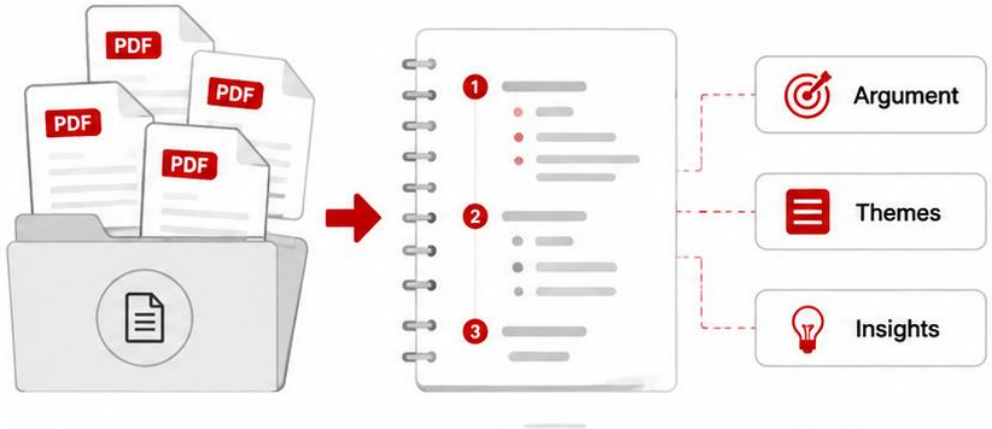
- Fees advertised above review standards
- Unrealistic turnaround times
- No editorial board or contact details
- Aggressive email invitations

Remember: Citation counts measure attention, not correctness.
A highly cited paper can still be the one your study corrects.

Tip:
When in doubt, be conservative.
It's better to exclude now than to build on weak evidence later.

03
Reading and Synthesising

Turning a folder of PDFs into an organised argument.



1. Organise

Collect and store your PDFs. Name and sort them clearly.

2. Read Actively

Skim, then read closely. Note key points, methods, and findings.

3. Extract

Pull out data, concepts, quotes, and evidence that matter.

4. Synthesise

Group related ideas. Compare, contrast, and look for patterns.

5. Build Argument

Turn your synthesis into a clear, logical story that answers your question.

Key idea: Read with purpose, extract what matters, connect the dots, and build a coherent argument.

Reading in Three Passes

EFFICIENT READING

You cannot read fifty papers closely. Decide early which ones deserve the third pass.

1. Triage — Keep or not?
2. Extract — What matters?
3. Engage — Trust and learn?

1 PASS 1 — ABOUT 5 MINUTES

Triage



- Title, abstract, and conclusion
- Skim headings and figures
- Decide: relevant, maybe, or discard

Most sources stop here, and should.

2 PASS 2 — ABOUT 20 MINUTES

Extract



- Introduction, method, and results
- Record design, sample, and findings
- Note the limitations the authors admit

This is where your matrix gets filled.

3 PASS 3 — AN HOUR OR MORE

Engage



- Read fully and critically
- Question whether the data support the claim
- Trace its key references

Reserved for the handful of core studies.

Remember: Move quickly in Pass 1, focus in Pass 2, think deeply in Pass 3. The goal is not to read everything, but to understand what matters.

Keep (relevant) | Maybe (park for later) | Discard (not relevant)

What to Record for Every Source



NOTE-TAKING

Capture the essentials once, clearly, and consistently.

1	**Full citation and DOI**	Capture once, in your reference manager, in the style your department requires.
2	**Question and purpose**	What the authors set out to find — in their words, condensed into one line.
3	**Context and participants**	Country, setting, level, sample size. This is what determines transferability.
4	**Design and instrument**	How the data were produced. You will reuse this in your methodology chapter.
5	**Key findings**	The result that matters for your question, not every result in the paper.
6	**Limitations and your comment**	What the authors admit, plus one line on how the study relates to yours.

Example: Smith, J. (2022). Title of article. *Journal Name*, *10*(2), 123–140. https://doi.org/10.xxxx/xxxxx

Example: To examine the effect of feedback timing on student engagement in asynchronous courses.

Example: Indonesia; first-year university students; online course; $n = 256$.

Example: Quantitative survey; Learning Engagement Scale (LES); validated in prior studies.

Example: Timely feedback is positively associated with engagement ($\beta = 0.32$, $p < .01$).

Example: Small sample and single institution. My study extends this in a larger, multi-institution sample.

Tip: Record page numbers with every quotation as you read. Reconstructing them later is the most avoidable waste of a week.

The Literature Matrix

A TOOL THAT WRITES THE REVIEW FOR YOU

One row per source, one column per thing you need to compare.
When the table is full, the themes are already visible.



1. Read — Collect key details

2. Record — Enter in the matrix

3. Compare — Look for patterns and differences

4. Synthesise — Use insights to build your argument

Source	Context	Design	Key finding	Relevance to my study
Author (2019) *DOI: 10.xxxx/xxxxx*	Undergraduates, blended courses, Europe	Survey, n = 412	Faster feedback associated with higher participation	Supports the timing–engagement link; different delivery mode
Author (2021) *DOI: 10.xxxx/xxxxx*	First-year students, fully online, Asia	Interviews, n = 18	Students describe disengaging while waiting for marks	Gives the mechanism my survey cannot capture
Author (2023) *DOI: 10.xxxx/xxxxx*	Postgraduates, asynchronous, Australia	Quasi-experiment	No timing effect once workload is controlled	Contradicts the two above; the tension I will examine

Tips for using the matrix

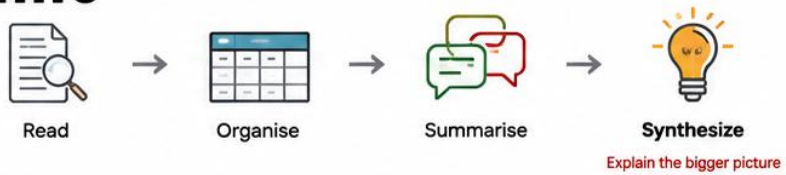
- Keep it consistent: use the same column headings.
- Be brief but precise; link to the page numbers.
- Add more columns if needed (e.g., Limitations, Theory, Country).
- Update as you read more sources.

Remember: Notice the last row: the disagreement between sources is not a problem for your review — it is the reason your study exists.

Summary and Synthesis Are Not the Same

THE CENTRAL SKILL

Move from reporting what each study says to building a coherent argument.



SUMMARY — SOURCE BY SOURCE

Retells each study in turn.

"Author (2019) studied 412 students and found faster feedback increased participation. Author (2021) interviewed 18 students and found they disengage while waiting. Author (2023) ran a quasi-experiment and found no effect."



Lists studies one after another

SYNTHESIS — CLAIM FIRST, SOURCES AS EVIDENCE

Builds a thesis and uses studies to support it.

"Evidence linking feedback timing to engagement is consistent in self-report studies (Author, 2019; Author, 2021) but weakens under controlled conditions (Author, 2023). The divergence follows the design rather than the setting: studies that measured perceived timing report an effect, while the one study that manipulated timing and controlled for workload does not. Whether timing matters independently of workload therefore remains unresolved in asynchronous undergraduate courses."



Compares, explains, and draws a conclusion

1. OPEN WITH YOUR CLAIM

- Start with the main idea you are arguing.
- Name the pattern you are investigating.

Good synthesis starts with a thesis, not a bibliography.

2. COMPARE, DON'T QUEUE

- Group studies by what they show.
- Explain why they agree or differ.

Look for patterns in methods, measures, and conditions.

3. END BY NARROWING THE GAP

- State what is still uncertain.
- Link directly to the need for your study.

Point clearly to the question your study will answer.

Four Ways to Organise the Review

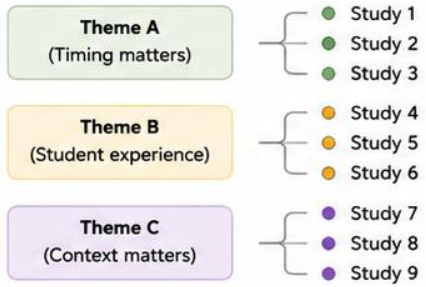
STRUCTURE

Different reviews need different maps. Choose the structure that best fits your question and the story you need to tell.

1. Thematic

Grouped by concept or debate.
The default, and the easiest to end in a gap.

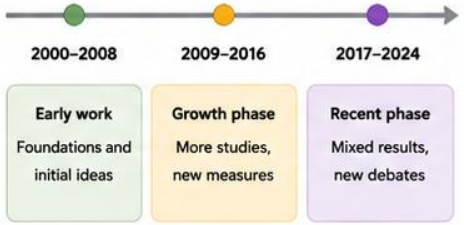
Example: Themes in feedback timing research



2. Chronological

Grouped by period.
Use only when the field genuinely shifted over time.

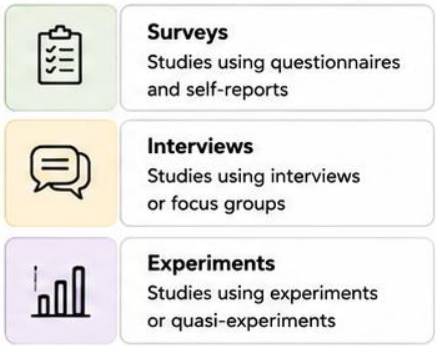
Example: Evolution of feedback timing over the years



3. Methodological

Grouped by how studies were done.
Useful when designs explain conflicting results.

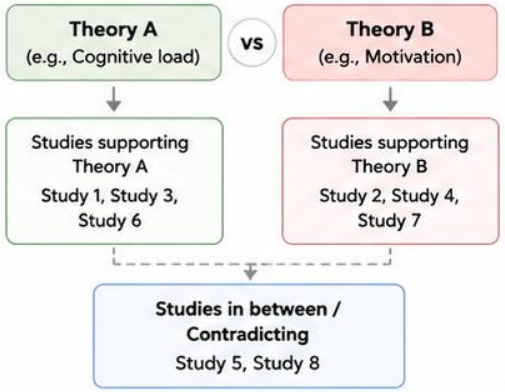
Example: Comparing by research design



4. Theoretical

Grouped by competing frameworks.
Use when your study takes a side.

Example: Competing explanations



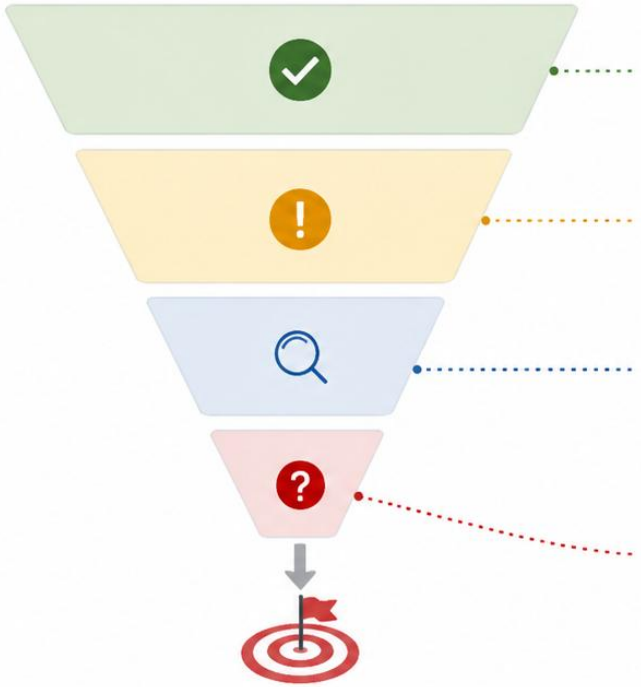
Key reminder:

- Announce the structure in your first paragraph.
- Use headings that name the themes (e.g., "Timing Effect" or "Student Experience"), not the authors.
- The right structure makes the patterns clear and your argument stronger.

The Review Is an Argument With a Destination

ARGUMENT ARC

Each layer narrows the field until the gap is the only place left to stand.



1 WHAT THE FIELD AGREES ON
The established findings you do not need to re-argue.
Show consensus and move on.

2 WHAT IS CONTESTED
Where results conflict, and the explanations offered so far.
Identify the disagreements and why they matter.

3 WHAT IS UNTESTED HERE
Findings established elsewhere but never in your context.
Point out what is known elsewhere, but not here.

4 WHAT REMAINS UNEXAMINED
The specific question no included study has answered.
Define the precise gap your study will fill.

THEREFORE, THIS STUDY
Your questions, arriving as the reader's own conclusion.

TIP: Write each layer in order. Every sentence should narrow the field. End with the gap and your purpose.

If your last paragraph could be deleted without the reader noticing, the review had no destination.

The Conceptual Framework

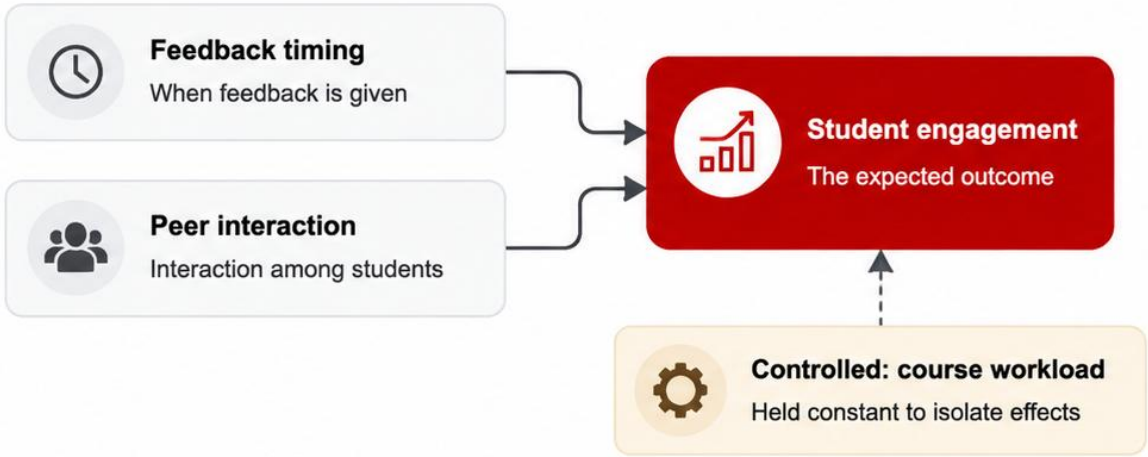
FRAMEWORK

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

An existing theory you adopt to explain the phenomenon, taken from published work and cited as such.

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

Your own map of the variables and the relationships you expect between them, assembled from the literature you just reviewed.



RULES FOR THE DIAGRAM

- Every box must appear in your research questions
- Every arrow must be supported by a cited source
- Explain it in prose; a diagram alone is not a framework

TIP: Keep the model simple and focused. Include only the variables that matter for answering your questions.

Inputs → Outcome --> Control

04 Writing the Section

Paragraphs, citations, and keeping the argument yours.



Paragraphs

- One idea per paragraph.
- Start with a topic sentence that shows how it fits your argument.
- Develop with evidence and analysis.
- End with a sentence that leads to the next step.

Citations

- Cite every idea, data, or quotation that is not yours.
- Use one consistent style (e.g., APA 7th).
- Include page numbers for direct quotations.
- Let citations support your claims, not replace them.

Keep the Argument Yours

- Explain what the evidence means.
- Compare sources and show patterns.
- Link back to your research questions and purpose.
- Build toward the gap your study will address.

Goal: A clear, well-supported narrative that leads the reader from what is known to what still needs to be found.

How the Written Section Is Laid Out

SECTION STRUCTURE

Part	What goes in it	Indicative length
Opening	• Scope of the review • How you searched (databases, keywords, dates) • How the section is organised	2–3 paragraphs
Theme 1, 2, 3…	• Grouped evidence under headings that name ideas • Compare and contrast sources • Evaluate the quality and relevance	The bulk of the section
Conceptual framework	• Variables and relationships your study will work with • Include a diagram and explain it	1–2 pages
Synthesis and gap	• What the reviewed work establishes • Where results conflict or are unclear • The specific question or gap your study will address	2–3 paragraphs

THE FLOW OF YOUR ARGUMENT



TIPS

- Use headings that name ideas, not author names.
- Every statement of fact or interpretation needs a citation.
- End by leading the reader clearly to the gap your study will fill.

The final paragraph of this section and the problem statement in your introduction must agree word for word about what the gap is.

The Anatomy of a Synthesis Paragraph

PARAGRAPH CRAFT

1 Claim

Open with the point this paragraph makes. Yours, not an author's.

Ask yourself:
What is the main idea I want to make here?

> *"Evidence linking feedback timing to engagement is consistent in self-report studies…"*

2 Evidence

Use two or more sources that agree with your claim.

Ask yourself:
Which sources say this too, and how can I put them together?

> *"…(Author, 2019; Author, 2021)"*

3 Evaluation

Compare, qualify, or explain the difference between them.

Ask yourself:
How are these studies similar or different, and why does it matter?

> *'…but weakens under controlled conditions, where workload is held constant (Author, 2023)."*

4 Link

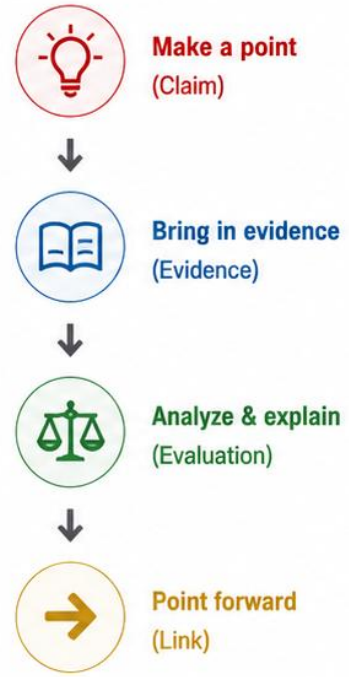
Point forward: what remains unsettled and what comes next.

Ask yourself:
What does this leave open, and what is the next step?

> *Whether the effect survives that control is therefore unresolved."*

The goal: Move the reader from what is known, through what is debated, to what is still unknown.

Four moves, one paragraph, one idea. If a paragraph needs two claims, it needs two paragraphs.



Citations and Reporting Verbs

ATTRIBUTION

INTEGRAL CITATION

"Author (2021) argued that students disengage while waiting for marks."

The author is the subject.
Use when the person or study matters.

NON-INTEGRAL CITATION

"Students disengage while waiting for marks (Author, 2021)." — The finding is the subject.

The finding is the subject.
Use most of the time in a synthesis.

QUICK GUIDE: WHEN TO USE WHICH?

Is the author or study the focus of your sentence?

YES → Use integral citation. (Author, year)

NO → Is the idea, finding, or result the focus of your sentence?

YES → Use non-integral citation. (Author, year)

Strength	Verbs (examples)	What you are signalling
Neutral	reported, examined, measured, observed, described	You are relaying what was done or found, without endorsing it.
Stance	argued, suggested, proposed, claimed, questioned	The author advanced a position that others might contest.
Strong	demonstrated, established, confirmed, showed	You accept the finding as settled — use sparingly, and only with strong evidence.

TIPS

- Let your verbs do the arguing, not your adjectives.
- Be consistent with your citation style.
- Vary your verbs to avoid repetition and show nuance.

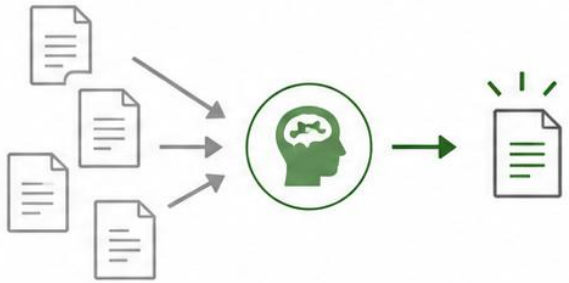
Your verb is an argument. *"Claimed" and "demonstrated" describe the same sentence very differently.*

Keeping the Argument Yours

VOICE

DO

- **Start paragraphs with** your claim, not with a citation
- **Group several** sources behind one sentence where they agree
- **Name disagreements** openly and offer an explanation
- **Paraphrase** in your own sentence structure, then cite
- Use **headings** that name themes, not author surnames
- Return regularly to what this means for your question



Read widely → Think critically → Write in your voice

YOUR GOAL

Show how the evidence fits together, why it matters, and what remains unknown—on the way to your gap.

AVOID

- "Author X said… Author Y said…" for paragraph after paragraph
- Long quotations used instead of your own explanation
- Reporting every study at the same level of detail
- Accepting a finding simply because it is published
- Reviewing sources that never reappear anywhere in your proposal
- Ending the section without saying what is missing

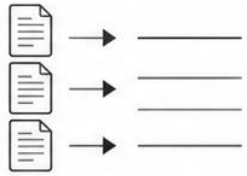
REMEMBER: A reviewer should be able to read only your first sentences and still follow the whole argument.

Where Literature Reviews Fail

COMMON FAILURES

1 It is a list, not a review

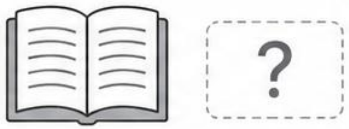
One paragraph per source, in the order they were read, with no comparison anywhere.



No synthesis, no links between studies.

2 No gap emerges

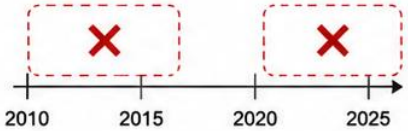
Thirty pages of competent summary that end without telling the reader what is missing.



No destination for the argument.

3 Only recent, or only old

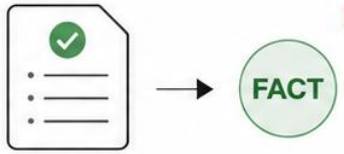
A review with nothing before 2020 has no foundations; one with nothing after has no relevance.



Context is lost at both ends.

4 Uncritical acceptance

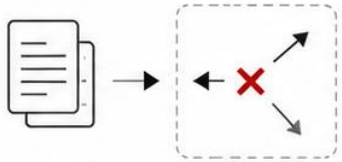
Every study reported as fact, with no attention to sample, design, or context.



No evaluation, no nuance.

5 Sources that go nowhere

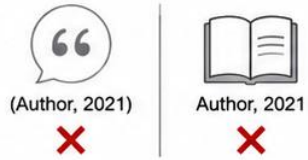
Work reviewed at length that never informs a question, a variable, or a method.



Lots of reading. No direction.

6 Citations that do not match

In-text citations missing from the reference list, or references never cited in the text.



Inconsistent and untrustworthy.

Remember: A literature review should build a clear path: what is known, what is debated, and what remains unanswered.

Integrity in the Literature Review

NON-NEGOTIABLES

1 Paraphrase properly



Changing a few words while keeping the sentence structure is **patchwriting**, and it is treated as plagiarism.

Instead: Rewrite in your own sentence structure and then cite.

Why: It shows understanding, not copying.

2 Cite what you actually read



If you know a study only through another author, cite it as reported in that author's work.

Instead: Use "**as cited in**" to give credit accurately.

Why: Prevents misattribution and errors.

3 Quote with page numbers



Direct wording needs quotation marks and a locator, every time, however short the phrase.

Instead: Quote sparingly and integrate with your own words.

Why: Gives credit and helps readers verify.

4 Verify every reference



AI tools produce plausible citations that do not exist. Check the DOI and open the paper before citing it.

Instead: Confirm the source exists, matches the claim, and is relevant.

Why: Avoids fake sources and false claims.

5 Represent findings fairly



Do not report only the result that suits your argument while omitting the authors' qualifications.

Instead: Report the full finding, including limits and context.

Why: Builds a balanced, credible argument.

6 Follow your institution's AI policy

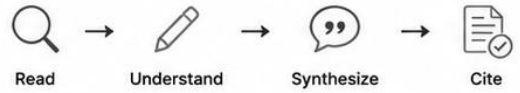


Disclose assistance where required. Undeclared use in a submitted proposal is misconduct in most institutions.

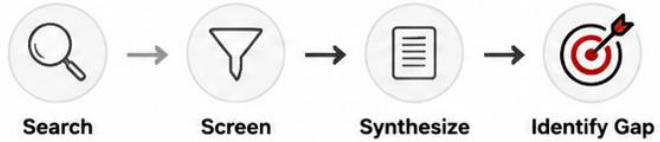
Instead: Declare tools used and how they supported your work.

Why: Transparency protects your integrity.

REMEMBER: *A fabricated citation is treated as fabricated data, not as a formatting error.*



Literature Review Checklist



BEFORE YOU SUBMIT THE DRAFT

- **The search strategy is described: sources, terms, dates, and limits**
  Readers can see how you looked for evidence and why it is sufficient.



- **Inclusion and exclusion criteria are stated and applied consistently**
  Readers trust that the studies you include belong in the review.



- **Sources are grouped by theme, with headings that name ideas**
  Studies are organized by what they show, not by author or date.



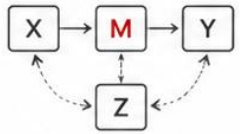
- **Every theme paragraph opens with a claim of your own**
  Your voice leads the argument, not the authors' voices.



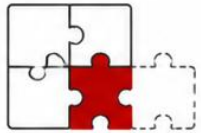
- **Disagreements between studies are named and explained**
  You compare findings and give reasons for differences.



- **The conceptual framework matches the variables in your questions**
  The diagram reflects the relationships you plan to test.



- **The section ends with a gap that matches your problem statement**
  It clearly states what is still unknown in your context.



- **Every in-text citation appears in the reference list, and vice versa**
  Every citation can be found, and every source is cited.

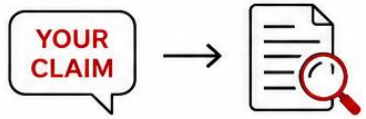


QUICK TEST: Print the section and read only the first sentence of each paragraph. **If that alone tells the story, the synthesis works.**

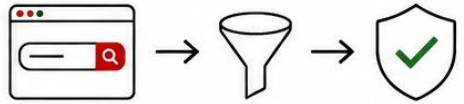
Five Things to Remember

KEY TAKEAWAYS

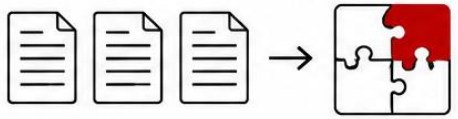
1. **A review argues; a summary reports**
   Make a point in each paragraph, and back it up with evidence.
   Why: Your voice makes the argument clear and meaningful.



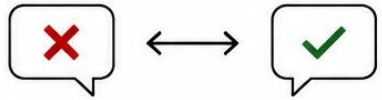
2. **Describe your search, and defend it**
   Explain where, what, when, and how you searched—and why it is enough.
   Why: Transparent methods make your review credible and reproducible.



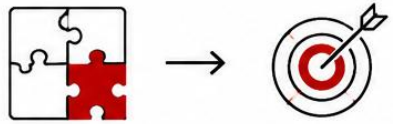
3. **Themes come from the sources**
   Let patterns in the literature shape your headings and structure.
   Why: This keeps your review accurate and genuinely insightful.



4. **Disagreement is an opportunity**
   Compare conflicting findings and explain what might account for them.
   Why: Contradictions reveal the gap your study can address.



5. **The section must end in your gap**
   Close by stating what is still unknown—and why it matters.
   Why: A clear gap connects your review to your research question.



Remember: Read your section out loud. If the first sentence of each paragraph does not tell the story, revise it.



Thank You

Bring your literature matrix to Week 4.

Week 3 of 4 · Research Proposal Writing